and all that season, it certainly felt like it. And that made a big difference. We won our first home game of the season 2–1; and I don't think I lost my own battle with Julian Dicks.

For a young team, every game meant that we would find out more about ourselves, about what we could and couldn't do. We believed in our own ability but that didn't mean we didn't have a lot to learn from week to week. Ten days after the West Ham game, we went up to face Blackburn at Ewood Park for one of the biggest fixtures of the season. Three months earlier, Blackburn had won their first Premiership title, finishing one point ahead of us despite losing to Liverpool on the last day of the season. They had a strong, experienced team, with Chris Sutton and Alan Shearer up front. Going there, so early in the season, made it a very big night: the boss didn't say it, but I think it was a match we thought we couldn't afford to lose.

I remember two incidents really clearly. Early on, I tried a long ball that didn't come off—a Hollywood pass, probably—and Roy Keane had a go at me about it; in fact he absolutely ripped me apart. Before I knew it, I was having a go back at him. Sometimes the passion of the moment can take you by surprise. Roy does it to his team-mates all the time. It's part of his game and what people need to understand is that there's nothing personal about it. It doesn't matter to Roy if you've been playing for United for ten years or just ten games; if he thinks he needs to, he'll hammer you. It's all about wanting to win. That night at Ewood Park was the first time I'd been on the end of one of those tirades. It worked. It always works: Keano having a go at you fires you up because you know he's doing it for a reason, not just for the sake of losing his temper. Whether he's right or wrong, he always gets a reaction.

Later on, with the score at 1–1, I remember Lee Sharpe went into a challenge on the edge of their penalty area. The ball rolled out towards me and I swiveled to line myself up and then curled a shot into the top right-hand corner. That goal was the winner. To do something like that, in a game as important as that, was a really big thing for me. And the goal and the result were just as big for the club. That game was in the middle of a run of five straight wins that followed us getting beaten at Villa. Win nothing with kids? I think United supporters, at least, were starting to wonder if maybe we could.

Not that anyone got carried away by my goal up at Blackburn, or by anything else. Personally, I still couldn't quite believe I was playing for the first team. I was just as excited by that as I was by scoring. As a group of young players, we weren't the kind of characters to go round shouting the odds. In fact, the dressing room during that season was probably as quiet as a